

The Elite Theory Perspective: the Iron Law of Oligarchy and the Claremont Deficit Crisis

A cross-meeting report. It reads the eleven-year record of the Claremont School Board and the SAU 6 board (January 2015 to September 2026) through Robert Michels' theory of organizational oligarchy, and asks how far the organizational dynamics that theory predicts account for the fiscal acts that produced the district's \$5.01 million deficit, and what those dynamics cost the district's voters. It is a degree-of-fit analysis between a theory and a distribution of events. It is not a finding about any person, and it attributes no motive to anyone.

BODIES Claremont School Board (including its finance subcommittee, budget hearings and deliberative sessions); SAU 6 Joint Board	RECORD 315 speaker-attributed dialogue files built from the Cablecast recordings, 1/21/15 to 9/16/26; 255 Claremont board sessions and 58 SAU 6 sessions carry a parseable date; the deficit timeline page of 9/1/26; the roster reconstructions in Scripts/roster_2015_2023.md and Scripts/briefing.md	THEORY Robert Michels, <i>Political Parties</i> (1911; English translation by Eden and Cedar Paul, 1915). Supporting attributions: Mosca, Pareto, Bachrach and Baratz, Jouvenel, each named where used	MEASURES Per-meeting and per-era proxies computed on 9/27/26 from the dialogue files by Scripts/era_signatures.py , written to Output/Reports/signatures-by-meeting.csv and signatures-by-era-claremont.csv / -sau6.csv . Every number is a proxy over machine-attributed speech; the caveats are in the method section
STATUS The CBIZ forensic audit (engaged April 2026) had published no findings as of this date. The FY2024 and FY2025 audits were incomplete as of July 2026. Election dates used for the eras are the second Tuesday of March, computed and not yet verified against the city clerk's certified returns	VERIFICATION Every in-video citation below was machine-checked against Output/HTML/Dialogue/*.CSV : each seekto value is the whole-second floor of a real transcript start time and the displayed H:MM:SS renders from that same value		

The question and the warrant

Michels' claim, made about socialist parties and trade unions before the First World War, is that any organization large enough to need a permanent staff and a standing leadership will come to be governed by that staff and that leadership, whatever its constitution says. Three things drive it. The membership cannot do the technical work itself, so it delegates, and the delegates acquire a competence the membership cannot check. The delegates come to hold their positions for long periods, and to choose the people who join them. And the members, once they have delegated, are grateful, deferential, and attentive only in crises. His summary sentence is "Who says organization, says oligarchy" (Michels 1915, Part Six, ch. 2). He did not claim the tendency could be abolished, only that it could be recognised and resisted.

A school board is a small elected body with a statutory administration under it (RSA 194-C for the SAU; RSA 189 for the board) and a legislative body above it, the voters at the annual meeting who adopt the budget under RSA 40:13 and who alone can authorise retention of surplus under RSA 198:4-b. It is therefore a two-level test of Michels: does the board become dependent on its administration, and do the voters become dependent on the board? This report asks what the record shows about both, in the years in which the deficit was built (FY2016 to FY2022), the years in which it was carried unnoticed (FY2023 to spring 2025), and the crisis (August 2025 onward).

What this layer can claim is a degree of fit: that the distribution of speaking time, votes, appointments, audits and decisions across eleven years is or is not what the theory predicts, and that the fiscal acts in the deficit timeline sit or do not sit where the theory says they would. What it cannot claim is that any individual intended any of it. Michels' mechanism does not require intent; that is its point. And the record has holes, named below, where an absence cannot be asserted.

Method: eras, measures and baselines

Eras are defined by the March school board election. Each era runs from the second Tuesday of March in one year to the day before it in the next, so "2019" is March 2019 to March 2020. For every dialogue file the script classifies each speaker's role (chair, vice chair, other board member, administration, member of the public, outside expert, city official, unidentified) from the Role column, sums speaking seconds by class, and computes for the board members the chair's share of board speech, the top speaker's share, and a Gini coefficient of speaking time. It also counts, per ten hours of meeting, occurrences in the transcript of roll-call votes, the voice-vote formula ("all those in favor"), nonpublic session, the word audit, and turns taken by members of the public. Baselines are the same board in other eras; no comparable district record exists in this project.

Claremont School Board sessions by era (board meetings, special meetings, finance subcommittee, budget hearings, deliberative meeting length. Counts are per ten hours of recording. Chair named is the presiding officer for most of the era.

Era	Chair	Meetings	Hours	Board share	Admin share	Public share	Chair share of board speech	Board Gi
2016	Rapp	22	49.9	.33	.44	.08	.30	.31
2017	Rapp, then Sprague from 1/31/18	31	70.9	.30	.42	.08	.25	.32
2018	Sprague	23	44.8	.38	.35	.05	.41	.40
2019	Sprague	22	31.9	.34	.36	.08	.56	.46
2020	Sprague	13	26.3	.38	.49	.04	.38	.44
2021	Sprague	18	34.8	.36	.48	.07	.49	.48
2022	Petrin	20	37.9	.31	.42	.13	.51	.39
2023	Whitney	28	47.0	.31	.53	.08	.58	.39
2024	Whitney	25	38.1	.32	.45	.08	.58	.46
2025	Whitney	32	71.0	.42	.28	.17	.65	.47
2026 (to 9/16)	Crawford	16	30.9	.46	.40	.05	.70	.55

Caveats that apply to every number above. Speaker attribution is automatic and was verified for sustained turns, not for short exchanges; 14.8 per cent of rows in the 2015 to January 2023 files are Unidentified, against under 1 per cent from 2023 on, so pre-2023 shares are understated for whoever speaks briefly, usually board members. Nonpublic sessions are spliced out of the recordings, so their length is not measured, only their frequency. The 2020 roll-call rate reflects remote meetings under the pandemic emergency orders, which required roll calls, not a change in board practice. "Audit" counts words, not decisions. The five meetings of January 2015 to March 2016 are omitted as too few to measure. The eras before 2018 are baselines for the eras after, and nothing more.

Three things in the table do the work below. The administration's share of speaking time exceeds the whole board's in every era from 2016 through 2024 except 2018, reaches .53 in 2023, and falls well below it only in the crisis year 2025. The chair's share of board speech roughly doubles between the Rapp era (.25 to .30) and the Sprague era (.56 by 2019), stays above .5 under Petrin and Whitney, and reaches .70 under Crawford in a 2026 sample of sixteen meetings. And the public's share of time never reaches .10 in any era before the 2022 election, and reaches .17 only in the year the deficit is announced.

Mechanism one: technical indispensability, and a board that could not check its own numbers

Michels' first cause of oligarchy is technical. The membership "cannot itself carry on the work," so it delegates to people who acquire "a specialised competence" that the membership can neither replicate nor evaluate (Michels 1915, Part One, ch. 1, "The Need for Organization" and "Technical and Administrative Causes"). The relevant competence here is the year-end fund balance: the single number, reported on the DOE-25 and the MS-25 each autumn, that determines how much of the appropriation the voters have already made will be raised in taxes and how much will be offset by surplus. In Claremont that number was produced by one office, the business administrator's, and it entered the record only through that office's voice.

The autumn 2020 decision, act 2 in the deficit timeline, was thought to have no retrievable record. It is on tape. On October 7, 2020, Business Administrator Richard Seaman told the board he had asked members that day to sign the DOE-25 and that "last year, we had about a little, just a little bit over \$2 million surplus" (1:25:23). He explained the two ways of holding some of it back, recommended the contingency fund under RSA 198:4-b that "we've done, boy, I think every year for the last probably 7 or 8 years," and proposed raising it from 2.5 to the newly permitted 5 per cent of net assessment, about \$845,000 (1:30:50). He then stated what the mechanism would do with the remainder: "what remains of the 2 million would go back to taxpayers. And what's going to go back to taxpayers is still well over \$1 million" (1:36:21). Jason Benware moved the 5 per cent retention, Michael Petrin seconded, and the chair called a roll call, as the remote meetings of 2020 required (1:40:04). No member asked whether the \$2 million figure had been audited. Five years later the district's business administrator told the same board that the balance actually available for FY2020 had been \$966,213 and that \$1,731,546 had been applied to reduce taxes (0:19:46). The two accounts are not reconciled here; they are both on the record.

The point for the theory is not the arithmetic but the structure of the exchange. The board had one source for the number, took it, and did the one thing available to it, which was to retain the maximum the statute allowed. That is the dependence Michels describes: the delegates were not negligent by the standard of what they could see, they were incapable of seeing more. The board's own vice chair said as much on October 1, 2025, after the interim business administrator had explained how the FY2022 tax rate was set from a surplus that did not exist: "the business administrator comes with this information and tells us that this is the fact. How does the board then dig in to try to find out that this is not the fact? The vote was to give back 1.2 million. How do we not trust the BA?" (3:03:12).

The same structure governs the grant side of the deficit. Federal grants reimburse spending after the district files for it, and the district did not file (Campo, 8/5/26, 0:55:42; Crawford, 0:56:00). The board heard the filing posture stated on March 1, 2023, when Assistant Superintendent Mike Koski reported that of a \$2.879 million ESSER II allocation only \$400,000 had been reimbursed, "the bulk of that is waiting," and added, "I've never done Esser reporting, I'm not sure how that works actually" (0:09:49). The same allocation had been described by Seaman five months earlier as budgeted to within \$503,663 (1:41:52). Nobody on the board asked, on either occasion, how a district that spends first gets its money back, or how long it had been waiting. The voters, who at the February 2020, 2022 and 2023 deliberative sessions heard the revenue side of the budget presented by the business administrator alone, including the "fund balance to reduce taxes" line (0:38:36; 0:20:54; 0:20:57), were one further step removed.

Michels distinguished dependence born of the leaders' skill from dependence born of the members' lack of it, and both are present. The record shows a district that lost its financial expertise repeatedly (five business administrators, two of them interim, and five superintendents, three of them interim or acting, between June 2018 and September 2025) and a board that had no independent expertise to fall back on. That is a capacity failure of a small district, and the report says so. But the theory predicts exactly this outcome from exactly this arrangement: the less the delegates can check, the more the office that holds the numbers governs, whoever happens to hold it.

Mechanism two: the suspended check, known and tolerated

Delegation is safe to the extent that the delegating body keeps an independent check. The board's only independent check on the business office was the annual audit, and the record now shows how long the board knew it had none.

On September 5, 2018, Acting Superintendent Cory LeClair told the board that "we had had 14 outstanding audits last December" across the SAU's entities, of which seven were done, and presented the Claremont audit for fiscal year 2014 (0:15:02). On February 20, 2019, Business Administrator Michael O'Neill said that when he started in 2015 the auditors "had just issued 12," that the district was "three years behind and the goal has always been to catch up, but it never happens" (1:18:24); Rebecca Zullo confirmed on the record that "the audits weren't even done from 2012" (1:20:35). On November 20, 2019, the auditor himself came. Michael Campo of Plodzik and Sanderson told the board that the firm's goal was to finish fiscal year 2019 "in time for the federal clearinghouse, which is March 31st of 2020. That would put you back on track to a normal audit cycle" (0:10:32), and then: "my firm does roughly 170 municipal audits a year, of which over 100 of them are school districts. I don't say it with pride. This has been one of our most delinquent clients in the history of a 40, 45 year firm" (0:12:21). The chair's response was that this was "very reassuring"; the vice chair's was "I feel like I can sleep tonight finally after three years on this board" (0:15:19). The board then went into nonpublic session.

The March 2020 target was missed by about twenty months. On November 18, 2021, Seaman told the SAU 6 board that the auditors were "about to finish up the fiscal year 19 audit. As you know we've been behind on audits and catching up," and hoped to have 2019, 2020 and 2021 done within the year (0:30:23; 0:30:59). Between those two dates the board had accepted the unaudited FY2020 "surplus" (above) and, on the five recorded autumn 2021 board meetings (9/1, 9/15, 10/20, 11/3 and 12/1/21), had no discussion of the FY2021 fund balance or of the annual re-approval of the retention that Seaman had said in 2020 "needs to be re-approved each year" (1:31:57). That absence is asserted only

for the recorded meetings; no minutes for 2021 are published, and the 11/17/22 board meeting of the following autumn has no transcript in this corpus.

The measure that best captures the suspended check is the simplest. After November 20, 2019, no auditor is attributed a single turn before the Claremont School Board until March 5, 2025, when Campo returned to present the FY2020 audit and told the board that "the damage had been done because we were years behind" (0:27:37). That is a gap of sixty-three months, spanning the three tax-rate filings that opened the deficit. It is subject to the attribution caveat (an unidentified presenter would not be counted), but a presentation of the length Campo gave in 2019 would not plausibly be lost among short unidentified turns.

The board was not without warning inside that gap. Carolyn Towle asked in September 2019 that the board "kept up on what the audits, how the audits were coming and the results of those" as a standing matter (0:44:53); the word "audit" then falls from 19.7 mentions per ten hours in the 2019 era to 7.6 in 2020 and 6.0 in 2021 (table above). Seaman told the January 2020 deliberative session that the fund balance would be "about \$400,000" and that the figure would be settled "when we complete our audit, the audit is underway for fiscal 19" (0:38:36); the voters adopted the budget on that basis. In Michels' terms the check was not removed by anyone. It lapsed, everyone with standing to insist on it was told that it had lapsed, and the body whose duty it was to insist did not put the question to itself in a form that required an answer. Bachrach and Baratz (1962) call this the non-decision: the issue that is never placed on the agenda in a form that could be voted down.

OBSERVATION The forensic audit the board asked about in 2019 and did not get

The clearest single instance of an elected body raising its own check and being talked out of it is in the SAU 6 record of spring 2019. The idea of "some sort of forensic audit of the business office" had been raised "a few meetings ago"; the acting superintendent reported that she had asked counsel, who sent her to the auditing firm, which said a forensic audit "is typically done when there is a concern of questionable or illegal activity" and would be "probably a five year process, to the tune of hundreds of thousands of dollars," and steered her toward an efficiency study (0:53:08; 0:54:07). The board reduced the proposal to an efficiency study capped at \$5,000, then on April 11, 2019 voted to "wait until Mr. Tempesta has started working for the SAU 6 before we do an efficiency study" (1:02:56). On August 21, 2019, the new superintendent told the Claremont board that a forensic audit "is really an ordeal, this kind of an assumption of foul play" (0:34:46). No efficiency study is mentioned again in the 2019 or 2020 recordings. In April 2026 the district engaged CBIZ Forensic Consulting for about \$50,000, after two firms had declined and the State Police had urged it (deficit timeline, "The crisis breaks").

Sources: recordings 10304, 10321, 10506 at the times linked; Claremont-Deficit-Crisis-Timeline.HTML, Apr 2026 entry.

Mechanism three: the stability of leadership and the choosing of successors

Michels' second body of causes is the leaders' own position: once installed, they stay, and they come to select who joins them (Michels 1915, Part Two, "The Stability of Leadership"; Part Six, "The Conservative Basis of Organization"). A school board with three-year staggered terms is designed against this. The Claremont record shows the design being overtaken.

Presiding officers of the Claremont School Board, 2015 to 2026, from the roll-call and organizational-meeting record. Confidence notes follow the roster file.

Period	Chair	Vice chair	How the office changed hands
2015 to 2/3/16	Richard Seaman	not established	Seaman leaves the board March 2016; returns as business administrator 10/2/19
3/16/16 to 1/31/18	Brian Rapp	Chris Irish	Rapp elected 4-3 over Becky Ferland; removed with Irish by a 5-2 vote on 1/31/18 (Valley News, 2/2/18)
1/31/18 to 4/6/22	Frank Sprague	Rebecca Zullo (to 2020), Heather Whitney (from 5/6/20)	Sprague chairs four years and two months, through the three autumn filings that opened the deficit
4/6/22 to 3/14/23	Michael Petrin	Heather Whitney	Petrin had chaired the SAU 6 board 3/28/19 to 4/21/22; loses the one-year seat March 2023, returns as a write-in March 2024
3/2023 to 3/18/26	Heather Whitney	Frank Sprague (to 9/3/25), Michael Petrin (from 3/19/25)	Officers re-elected by uncounted voice vote 3/20/24; Sprague resigns 9/3/25, is reinstated by the board 3-2 on 11/5/25, and is defeated at the polls 3/10/26
3/18/26 onward	Candace Crawford	Michael Petrin	Crawford elected chair by voice vote, "the ayes have it," no count (0:05:13); Petrin's motion to step aside for Whitney fails on a 3-3 tie

From January 31, 2018 to March 18, 2026, four people held every chair and vice-chair term: Sprague, Zullo, Whitney and Petrin. Three of them, Sprague, Petrin and Whitney, sat on the board for the whole of the deficit's formation (Sprague from March 2016, Petrin from March 2017 with a one-year gap, Whitney from March 2019) and were the chair, the vice chair and the vice chair of the preceding two years on the night the deficit was announced (8/14/25, 0:22:29). Michels' prediction is not that officers are bad but that they become the organization's memory and its voice; the chair's share of board speech, which rises from a quarter under Rapp to over half under Sprague, Petrin and Whitney (table above), is the measurable form of that.

The selection of successors is visible too. Of the seats that changed hands between 2016 and 2025, five were filled by the board itself rather than by the voters: Alex Herzog (November 2016), Rob Lovett Jr. (November 2018), Nicholas Stone (June 2021), Candace Crawford (July 2023, by a 4-2 hand vote over two other applicants, 0:55:46), and Frank Sprague (November 2025, reinstated after two deadlocked attempts to appoint anyone else, on the mover's stated ground that "he has the experience that I feel that we need," 2:16:49). Two other seats were filled by write-in (Skillen 2022, Petrin 2024), and the March 2024 election had no contested race (briefing, Addendum 2). Michels wrote that the mass's participation shrinks to ratification; a board that fills its own vacancies and whose elections go uncontested has reached that condition without anyone contriving it. The maintainer of this project was one of the two unsuccessful applicants in July 2023, which is disclosed in `CONFLICTS.md`; the fact is reported here because it is in the record, and nothing turns on it.

What the changing composition shows: patterns of circulation

Pareto's term for the replacement of one governing minority by another is circulation, and the crisis section below tests it the only way the measures allow, by asking whether turnover changed the concentration of speech. The composition record supports a second kind of test: who entered, by what channel, from where, and whether those who left came back. Read that way, the roster of the two boards and their administration from 2015 to 2026 shows six patterns. Each is stated as a behavior of the body over a population of events, with the events that instantiate it; none is a finding about any person's intent.

The elected and administrative elites are one recruiting pool. The line between the governed office and the governing board was crossed repeatedly and in both directions. Richard Seaman chaired the Claremont board in 2015 and through the deliberative session of February 3, 2016, left the board that March, and returned on October 2, 2019 as the SAU's business administrator, "coming to us with lots of experience" as the SAU chair put it on the night the hire was announced (0:02:55; 0:22:03). He then held the office that prepared the FY2020, FY2021 and FY2022 fund-balance figures examined under the first mechanism. Frank Sprague came to the board in March 2016 as a former administrator of the district's own high school, a former Stevens High School principal by the Valley News account of May 25, 2018, and by his own accounts on tape a guidance counselor, "the principal" (0:45:58), and the director of student services who "acted as the LEA" (0:46:52); the roster file records all three versions and does not reconcile them. Alex Herzog was appointed to the board in November 2016 and was the administrator directing the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center by February 2019, a post he held until the summer of 2024, when the superintendent funded a new position from "the money that we saved based on Alex's salary" (0:47:36). Candace Crawford, appointed in July 2023 and chair from March 2026, had by the account carried in the briefing file served on the board from 1991 to 2002 with six years as chair; that service is single-sourced there and is not asserted here beyond that. The Seaman case is the one that bears on the deficit: for three and a half years the board's dependence on its administration was dependence on a former chair, and the one person who had held both statuses produced the numbers the board could not check.

Administrative succession ran by promotion of insiders, and every outside hire was removed by the board. Each of the three superintendents who held the office between 2015 and January 2024 left by action of the SAU board: Middleton McGoodwin, whose parting with the board ("regret to inform you that it's necessary for us to part ways") was announced out of a nonpublic session on June 14, 2018 (0:16:21); Keith Pfeifer, interim from the summer of 2018, placed on paid leave in February 2019 and resigned that March; and Michael Tempesta, hired from Worcester, Massachusetts in March 2019 and terminated on January 11, 2024 by a motion "in accordance with paragraph nine of the contract" with six months' severance (0:06:15). With one exception, the outside interim Pfeifer, every acting or interim replacement was a sitting administrator of the SAU, and so was the one permanent appointment the record shows made without a search. On the night McGoodwin's departure was announced a Claremont member asked "who do we have currently on staff" who met the qualifications to act, and the assistant superintendent answered that she held the certification and would be willing (0:36:52; 0:37:21); Cory LeClair served as acting superintendent that summer and again from February to June 2019. On January 11, 2024 the motion that followed the termination appointed the Stevens principal, Christopher Pratt, interim superintendent effective the next day (0:08:11); he was made permanent in June 2024. On September 11, 2025 the SAU board accepted Pratt's resignation and in the next motion offered the interim post to the middle school principal, Kerry Kennedy, who kept the principalship concurrently (0:05:03; 0:05:57); the human resources director had been acting in the two weeks between. Dr. Tim Broadrick, in office from July 1, 2026 after a search that had drawn eight résumés by March 18 (briefing, Addendum 1), is the first superintendent since

Tempesta whose appointment the record shows as the product of a search. The business administrator's office turned over on the same scale: Michael O'Neill, heard through January 2019, a part-time interim in 2019, Seaman from October 2019 to his retirement effective April 14, 2023, an interim from Municipal Resources Inc. that spring, Mary Henry from July 2023 until her termination by mutual agreement effective November 4, 2025, and Matt Angell, interim, from August 22, 2025 (briefing, Addenda 2 and 8; 2025 to 2026 attribution report). Counting acting and interim tenures, the superintendency changed hands eight times between June 2018 and July 2026 and the business administrator's office five times, and the elected officers outlasted all of them: Sprague's chairmanship spanned four superintendents and the whole turnover from O'Neill to Seaman, Whitney's four superintendents and four holders of the finance office. Michels expected the permanent staff to outlast the elected amateurs. Claremont inverts the persons and keeps the relation. The board's continuity was continuity of people, and it did not accumulate into the capacity to check the office, because the indispensability described under the first mechanism attached to the office and each new holder inherited it whole; the administration's share of speaking time exceeds the board's in every era from 2016 through 2024 except one (table above) regardless of who held the office.

Exit from the governing pool was rarely permanent. Circulation in Pareto's sense implies replacement. What the roster shows is rotation within a small pool. Brian Rapp, removed as chair by the 5-2 vote of January 31, 2018 and defeated that March, was elected again on March 10, 2026 and sworn in on March 18 (0:01:52). Michael Petrin lost the one-year seat in March 2023, returned as a write-in in March 2024 ("so I'm new, we're back again," 0:09:32), was elected vice chair in March 2025, and kept the post in March 2026 when his own motion to step aside for the outgoing chair, offered because "someone that's been involved so heavily" should continue, failed on a 3-3 tie (0:07:15; 0:09:03; "so Mike stays," 0:09:46). Sprague resigned on September 3, 2025 and was reinstated by the board on November 5 (2:16:49). Steven Horsky resigned in October 2018, returned in March 2021, was elected SAU 6 chair on a 6-5 paper ballot on March 30, 2023 (0:06:44), and resigned "effective immediately" twelve weeks later (0:04:05). Seaman left the board in 2016 and came back as its finance officer; Crawford left in 2002 and came back by appointment; Donald Lavalette, whose appointment failed on 3-3 votes in October and November 2025, won a seat in March 2026. The March 2026 ballot, which the crisis section reads as the voters' correction, returned a 2018 chair to the board and was followed by the election of a chair from the 1990s. The pool circulated; it did not widen.

Attrition opened the appointment channel, and appointees were chosen for prior standing. The five appointments listed above were made possible by at least seven mid-term resignations (Becky Ferland, October 2016; Brent Ferland, March 2017; Patrick Adrian, 2017; Horsky, 2018 and 2023; Joshua Lambert, January 2023; Sprague, 2025) and one death in office (Carolyn Towle, May 2021), all in the roster file. Where the grounds for an appointment are audible they are experience: Crawford's prior service in 2023, and in 2025 Sprague "has the experience that I feel that we need" (2:16:49), against the alternatives stated on the record, which were the voters in March (2:13:49) or, under RSA 671:33 as counsel had explained it five weeks earlier, the city council (1:44:14; 2:19:27). The Crawford vote of July 19, 2023 is the sharper case for the theory. The four members who chose her were the board's four newest, all seated since March 2022, and the chair and vice chair voted no (0:55:46; briefing, Addendum 2). The entrants selected the old guard over two outside applicants. Michels' word for what follows is amalgamation: new members attach themselves to the experienced, and the experienced then preside over them (Michels 1915, Part Six, ch. 2).

Membership circulated; the officer function did not. From January 31, 2018 to March 18, 2026 four people held every chair and vice-chair term (table above). Across the 2023, 2025 and 2026 elections six new members were elected (Arlene Hawkins and Jennifer Gallagher in 2023, William Madden and Loren Howard in 2025, Lavalette and Rapp in 2026) and one was appointed, to a seven-seat board, and the chair's share of board speech rose from .58 to .70 while the Gini coefficient rose from .39 to .55 (era table). The only contested elections of a Claremont chair in eleven years are at the beginning of the record: Rapp 4-3 over Becky Ferland on March 16, 2016, and the removal of Rapp and Irish on January 31, 2018, moved by the vice chair against himself (roster file, section 7; Valley News, 2/2/18). No later Claremont officer election in the record carries a count; those of March 20, 2024 and March 18, 2026 were voice votes with no tally announced (briefing, Addenda 7 and 1). The subcommittee assignments read into the record on March 18, 2026 follow the same line: the two newly sworn members hold nine subcommittee seats between them and chair none (briefing, Addendum 1).

The SAU 6 board was the one arena of contested succession, and it closes on July 1, 2026. The joint board's chair was decided by counted vote more often than the Claremont chair, and the contest had a stated axis, the balance between the two towns. On June 14, 2018 the outgoing Unity chair said she had "found it a nice balance to have a Unity member and a Claremont member sitting at these two seats" and that "prior to this there was two Claremont members, and Unity was definitely not as aware of what was happening" (2:17:29); Marjorie Erickson of Unity was then elected 6-4 over Petrin by a show of hands (2:19:32). On March 30, 2023 the Claremont chair nominated Horsky on the ground that Claremont lacked representation at the SAU, a member who had "been very engaged and assertive about the needs of the Claremont School Board" (0:03:25), a Unity member answered that Erickson's chairmanship "allows Unity to have some representation" (0:03:54), and Horsky won the paper ballot 6-5. The succession ran Ferland (Claremont)

to October 2016, Sara Lowe (Unity) to June 2018, Erickson (Unity) to March 2019, Petrin (Claremont) to April 2022, Erickson again, Horsky (Claremont) for twelve weeks, and Hawkins (Claremont) from late 2023 (roster file, sections 2 and 7; briefing, Addendum 2). The Unity members were also the only recorded dissent at the Tempesta termination, one no and one abstention (briefing, Addendum 2). Unity's withdrawal from the SAU, effective July 1, 2026, removes the one structural counter-elite the arrangement contained.

What these patterns add to the third mechanism is specific. Michels' stability of leadership is usually read as the persistence of officers, and the officer table shows that. The composition record shows two further things the table does not: that the district's elected and administrative elites were recruited from one pool, with the crossing from board chair to business administrator at the center of the fiscal acts, and that the board answered every failure of an outside superintendent by promoting from within, so that the office whose indispensability the first mechanism describes was refilled each time from the same organization that depended on it. Both are checkable against the roll calls cited. The cautions are the ones stated for the roster: the years before February 2023 are reconstructed and single-sourced where the roster file marks them, and the 2026 measures rest on sixteen meetings.

Mechanism four: procedure as a screen between the body and its public

Michels observed that leaders govern through the forms of the constitution, not against them: the rules of procedure become the leadership's instrument, and formal compliance substitutes for accountability (Michels 1915, Part Two, "The Struggle Among the Leaders Themselves"; Part Six, ch. 2). Two forms carry that weight in this record.

The first is the uncounted voice vote. The deficit timeline established that of the money decisions it lists from February 2023 onward, exactly two carry a countable record: the February 15, 2023 restoration of \$600,000 to the default budget (4-2, read by the business administrator, [1:40:44](#)) and the September 3, 2025 borrowing (6-0, [2:59:39](#)). The \$36.1 million budget adoption ([2:25:07](#)), the \$424,000 retention ([1:17:38](#)), its reversal five months later ([0:35:51](#)), the \$350,000 retention ([1:31:31](#)), and the five withdrawals that emptied the trust funds ([0:36:45](#) to [0:40:15](#)) were all "all those in favor? Aye. Opposed?" with no count. The per-era table shows the practice is the board's norm across the whole record: roll calls run at six to nine per ten hours in every ordinary era, and the roll calls that do occur are overwhelmingly the ones statute requires, on entering nonpublic session under RSA 91-A:3 or under the 2020 emergency orders. The 2023 roll call is not the board's practice; it is the exception that measures the practice. The consequence for the voter is stated in the timeline and repeated here because it is the mechanism's product: the public record can say which four members voted to protect against the ESSER cliff in 2023 and cannot say which members voted to drain the reserves in 2025.

The second is the reversal of the one protective act by the same procedure that created it. On October 18, 2023 the business administrator asked the board to retain \$424,000 expressly because "I'm very worried about those audits and what they may reveal. And if you don't have the funds, you will run into a deficit warrant article" ([1:08:42](#)); the board did so on a voice vote ([1:17:38](#)). On March 6, 2024, a member moved to release it for special education costs, another member said "I haven't heard a compelling reason to retain the fund balance and withhold it from the taxpayers" ([0:32:16](#)), and it passed "seeing no opposition" ([0:35:51](#)). The reason given five months earlier was not revisited. The record does not show why. What it shows is a body in which the reason for a decision did not survive the meeting at which it was given, because nothing in the procedure carried it forward; the administration's reasoning was consulted when offered and not otherwise retained.

Nonpublic sessions are the third form and the one the measures can least interpret. Their frequency runs from 1.9 to 10.6 per ten hours across the eras and rises to 17.5 in the 2026 sample, which contains the superintendent search and the forensic audit engagement. The record shows the exemption named each time and the minutes sealed; it cannot show what was discussed, and this report draws no inference from the count except that the crisis moved more of the board's business out of view, which is what Jouvenel would predict (below) and what RSA 91-A permits.

Mechanism five: the leadership's interest in its own account of events

Michels' third set of causes is psychological: leaders identify the organization's interest with their own continuance, and treat challenges to their competence as attacks on the body (Michels 1915, Part Three, "The Exercise of Power and Its Psychological Reaction upon the Leaders"). The record contains several moments where the administration or the officers defended the account rather than opened it, and they are reported as tactics of the body over a population of events, not as anyone's motive.

In August 2019 the incoming superintendent framed a forensic audit as "an assumption of foul play" ([0:34:46](#)). In October 2022, when a member described the state's extraordinary grant handling as a "bait and switch," the superintendent answered that criticisms of "the current administration" were "unfair, they're unfounded, and they're not true" ([1:21:10](#)). On May 21, 2025, immediately after the over-returns were disclosed for the first time, the

superintendent said, "this was not on Mary Henry's watch or my watch. This was something that was inherited. We found it. We're fixing it" (0:24:17). On August 14, 2025, a member elected five months earlier said of the board's own presentation, "I think in April, we have the first inkling that there was a problem. I think the presentation was somewhat deceptive," and "We put fancy words and names to the problem. I think we hid behind our lawyer" (0:30:10). The administration's personnel exits were then handled by severance and termination agreements (Pratt, 9/12/25; Henry, November 2025; timeline, "The crisis breaks"), which is the ordinary form of such exits and also the form in which the least is said in public.

The theory does not need these statements to be insincere, and this report does not say they were. It needs only that the body's first response to each challenge was to defend the standing account, and that the account was corrected not from inside the board but by outside actors: the auditor (3/5/25, 5/21/25, 10/1/25), the interim business administrator (10/1/25), two reporters, and the state (deficit timeline, "The reporting timeline").

The fiscal acts, mapped to the mechanisms

Each fiscal act in the deficit timeline, the mechanism operating when it was taken, the era measure beside it, and the degree of fit with Michels' account. "Fit" is a judgment stated in words; the numbers are the ones relied on.

Act (timeline #)	Date	Mechanism	Measures relied on	Fit
Audits stop (1)	FY2016 to FY2019	Suspended check, known: 14 outstanding audits reported 9/5/18; "most delinquent client" 11/20/19	Admin share .42 to .44 (2016 to 2017); chair share of board speech .25 to .30; "audit" 3.2 to 4.2 /10h	Strong on the board's knowledge; the board was told repeatedly. Weak on strategy: the record shows staff turnover and lost files (O'Neill, 1:18:24), a capacity account
FY2020 balance applied (2)	10/7/20	Technical indispensability: the number arrives from one office and is acted on unexamined; the board retains the statutory maximum	Admin share .49 (2020, highest before 2023); public share .04 (lowest); auditor absent from board since 11/20/19	Strong. The act is the mechanism in miniature; the board did what it could and could not see what it needed to
FY2021 balance applied (3)	Autumn 2021	Non-decision: no discussion on the five recorded autumn meetings; retention not re-approved on the record	"Audit" 6.0 /10h, the lowest since 2017; FY19 audit still unfinished 11/18/21	Moderate, limited by the record: the absence holds only for recorded meetings
FY2022 balance applied (4)	Autumn 2022	Technical indispensability through a transition: the filing is the last of the retiring business administrator (retired 4/14/23); no vote located	Admin share .42; 11/17/22 meeting untranscribed	Moderate; same record limit
\$600,000 restored to default budget (5)	2/15/23	Counter-instance: a member names the structural risk and forces a counted vote	The only counted money vote among the 2023 to 2025 acts before 9/3/25; the 2020 retention was also a roll call, under the remote-meeting rules	Cuts against the theory, and shows what resistance to it looks like
Grant posture reported, unchallenged (6)	3/1/23	Technical indispensability: the officer reporting the posture states he has never done the reporting	Admin share .42 (2022 era); .53 in the era that followed, the highest in the record	Strong
\$424,000 retained against missing audits (7)	10/18/23	Counter-instance, initiated by the administration, not the board	Voice vote	Mixed: the correct diagnosis, from the office the board depended on
FY2025 budget adopted; ESSER positions absorbed; modular unit bought with ESSER (8)	1/17/24	Procedure as screen: uncounted voice vote on \$36.1 million	Voice votes 20.4 /10h, roll calls 8.9 /10h (2023 era)	Strong on form

Act (timeline #)	Date	Mechanism	Measures relied on	Fit
\$420,000 released (9)	3/6/24	Non-retention of the body's own reasoning; voice vote	Same	Strong
\$350,000 retained, rest returned (10)	10/16/24	Technical indispensability: the tax-rate filing the termination letter later blamed	Auditor still absent; "audit" 22 /10h as the FY2020 audit nears	Strong
FY2026 budget on a one-year aid jump; pre-K cut; property bought in nonpublic (11)	1/7/25	Procedure as screen; dissent recorded in writing, decision by unanimous voice vote	Nonpublic 8.4 /10h	Moderate
\$888,998 drawn from trusts (12)	5/7/25	Technical indispensability at the end: five motions in twelve minutes reimbursing spending already made, uncounted	Board share rises to .42 as the board begins to speak for itself	Strong

The crisis: concentration, and the mass's brief return

Bertrand de Jouvenel's thesis in *On Power* (1945) is that crises transfer authority upward and outward, to whoever can act, and that the transfer outlasts the crisis. The record fits it. After August 14, 2025, the decisions that mattered were taken by or on the advice of the interim business administrator ("I have discovered approximately \$5 million in outstanding overdue invoices and liabilities," 0:18:34), the board's counsel ("it's like a payday loan," timeline, 9/3/25), the lender of the \$4 million reimbursement anticipation note, TMS Consulting, the legislature (the revolving loan fund; SB 586 making annual audits mandatory), and the forensic auditor. Inside the elected body the same movement appears: the board's share of speech rises from .32 to .42 and the chair's share of it from .58 to .65 in the 2025 era, and to .70 in 2026, while the administration's share falls to .28 before recovering to .40 under the new superintendent (table). The board did not become more collegial in the crisis. It became more concentrated, in its chair, at the same time as authority over the outcome left the room.

Michels held that the mass re-enters only intermittently and at moments of crisis, and then usually to ratify. The public's share of speaking time, never above .08 before 2022, reaches .17 in the 2025 era, with 381 public turns per ten hours; the Stevens High School meeting of August 20, 2025 (1:26:54) is its peak. The March 10, 2026 ballot then rejected a budget cap 1,345 to 560, approved the \$42.9 million budget 1,537 to 310, authorised the sale of two buildings, and unseated the longest-serving member (timeline, "The crisis breaks"). That is Pareto's circulation, and the only form in which it is testable here: whether turnover changed the measures. Across the 2023, 2025 and 2026 elections seven new members joined a seven-seat board and the concentration measures did not fall; they rose. The 2026 sample (sixteen meetings, half of them in the superintendent transition) forbids a firm claim, and the report makes none beyond this: the record so far does not show new members diluting the chair's share, and Michels predicted, against Pareto, that what occurs is less a circulation of elites than an amalgamation of new leaders with old (Michels 1915, Part Six, ch. 2).

The anti-democratic effects

The question asked of this layer was what the organizational dynamics cost the district's democracy. The record supports six effects, each of them a product of the mechanisms above rather than of anyone's design.

The voters exercised their sovereignty on numbers nobody had checked. The annual meeting is the district's legislative body. At the deliberative sessions of February 2020, 2022 and 2023 the voters heard the revenue side of the budget, including the fund balance that would offset taxes, from one official (0:38:36; 0:20:54; 0:20:57), and adopted the appropriation on that presentation. Each following autumn the tax rate was set from the year-end balance the same office reported on the DOE-25, and for FY2020, FY2021 and FY2022 that balance was overstated by \$765,333, by \$1,323,810, and by roughly \$1.2 million in a year that had no surplus at all (0:19:46; 0:20:54; 3:00:38). The appropriations and the rates were lawful acts of the legislative body, taken in an ignorance that neither the voters nor the board could have dispelled, because the audit that would have corrected the number was years away. Formal democracy was intact; its content had been supplied by the office it was meant to govern.

The voters' one direct fiscal lever was too small to hold an unaudited surplus. Under RSA 198:4-b the voters authorise retention, capped by RSA 198:5. In October 2020 the board retained the newly permitted 5 per cent of net assessment, about \$845,000, of which about \$400,000 was already held (1:31:26; 1:31:57); everything above the cap,

"well over \$1 million" of a reported \$2 million surplus, flowed to the tax rate automatically (1:36:21). The retention statute is an instrument for holding a true surplus in reserve, not for holding a reported one pending an audit, and no instrument of the second kind existed. The lever the voters had authorised was smaller than the number the administration reported, and the board had nothing else. That is the practical meaning of the technical-indispensability mechanism: the democratic instrument was calibrated for a district whose numbers were true.

Individual accountability at the ballot box was defeated by the board's own procedure. A voter in March 2024, 2025 or 2026 who wished to hold a member responsible for the \$36.1 million budget, the release of the \$420,000 buffer, the \$350,000 retention or the \$888,998 drawn from the trusts could not learn from the public record how that member voted (timeline, "Every major money motion"). The voice vote is lawful and customary. Its effect, over a population of decisions, is to convert seven individual accountabilities into one collective one, which is precisely the transformation Michels describes: the body answers, and no one in it does.

The board's independent check was allowed to lapse for nine years with the board's knowledge, and the one alternative check it raised was deflected by its own administration. The audits had been behind since at least 2012 and lapsed altogether for FY2016 to FY2018, and the board was told in 2018, 2019 and 2021 how far behind they were (0:15:02; 0:12:21; 0:30:23). Its members expressed relief, not alarm, when the auditor promised to catch up (0:15:19). Its 2019 inquiry into a forensic audit was returned to it as a five-year, six-figure ordeal implying foul play, and it deferred the substitute to the incoming superintendent (0:54:07; 1:02:56). The effect is that the electorate's agents had no instrument with which to discover what their own agents were doing, and had consented, meeting by meeting, to not having one.

The composition of the board itself was partly withdrawn from the electorate. Five seats in nine years were filled by board appointment, two by write-in, and one election was wholly uncontested. In November 2025, with the deficit six weeks old, the board reinstated its resigned vice chair, on the ground of his experience, over the alternative of leaving the seat for the voters four months later (2:13:49; 2:16:49). Michels' phrase for this is the leaders' selection of their own successors; the Claremont record shows it as the ordinary working of a body that finds appointment easier than the alternative, and shows the voters correcting it, when given the chance, by defeating the reinstated member.

When the crisis came, the remedy was imposed from outside the electorate's reach, and the electorate's role was to absorb it. Nineteen teacher contracts, twenty positions, athletics, a school, and \$4 million borrowed at "payday loan" terms were decided in the fortnight after disclosure (timeline, Aug 22 to Sep 17, 2025), two of those meetings unrecorded. The state's response, the loan fund and SB 586, was legislative and permanent. What the voters were offered in March 2026 was a choice between a budget and a cap on it; they took the budget. Jouvenel's point is that this is how power grows: not by usurpation but by being the only thing left that works.

Where the record cuts against the Iron Law

A theory that fits everything explains nothing, and four things in this record resist it. The February 15, 2023 roll call (1:09:52; 1:40:44) is a member naming the structural deficit two and a half years before it broke and forcing a counted vote on protecting against it. The October 18, 2023 retention (1:08:42) is the administration itself warning the board and the board acting. The September 2025 policies requiring annual audits and routing federal grant documentation to members directly, and the appointment of a member as audit liaison (timeline, "What the board did that pointed the other way"), are the elected body building the check it had lacked. And the March 2026 ballot, which turned out the board's most senior member and rejected the cap while funding the schools, is the mass acting with more discrimination than Michels credited it with.

Michels would answer that none of these reverses the tendency; they interrupt it. The 2023 buffer was released five months later by the same procedure that created it. The new policies depend on the same office for compliance. And the measures for 2026, thin as they are, show the highest concentration of speech in the chair in the whole record. The honest statement of fit is this: the Iron Law does not explain why Claremont's audits stopped in 2016, or why its grant filings were not made; those are capacity failures in a small district that changed its business administrator four times and its superintendent five times in seven years. It explains why nobody with the authority to stop it did. The organization had arranged itself so that the only people who could see the problem were the people producing it, the only people who could insist were dependent on them, and the only people who could vote were told what to vote on by the same office. That arrangement was not chosen. It is what organization does when nothing pushes back, and for nine years nothing did.

Cautions, and what would falsify this account

The measures are proxies over machine-attributed speech, with the specific weaknesses noted under the era table; anyone relying on a number should read the rows behind it in the dialogue files. Acts 3 and 4 of the deficit, the FY2021

and FY2022 filings, are asserted from later testimony and not from a located vote; a Right-to-Know request for the autumn minutes and the MS-25 and DOE-25 packets of 2020 to 2022 would settle when and how they were taken, and a transcript of the 11/17/22 meeting would close the one gap in the autumn 2022 recordings. Rosters before February 2023 are reconstructed and single-sourced in places named in the roster file. The election dates bounding the eras are computed, not verified. The forensic audit may attribute the grant and fund-balance errors to conduct that this report has treated as capacity failure; if it does, the second mechanism (the suspended check) would carry more of the weight and the first (dependence) less, and the anti-democratic effects would be the same or worse.

The account would be falsified by any of the following: a located autumn 2021 or 2022 board discussion in which a member questioned the reported surplus and was answered; evidence that the auditor or another independent party presented to the board between November 2019 and March 2025; a run of contested elections or counted money votes in the 2019 to 2024 eras that the transcripts missed; or a fall in the chair's share of board speech and in the Gini coefficient after the 2025 and 2026 elections once the 2026 era has enough meetings to measure. Each of those is checkable from the same corpus and would be welcome.

Sources

Theory

- Robert Michels, *Political Parties: A Sociological Study of the Oligarchical Tendencies of Modern Democracy* (Leipzig, 1911; trans. Eden and Cedar Paul, New York: Hearst's International Library, 1915). Part One (technical and psychological causes of leadership), Part Two (autocratic tendencies of leaders; stability of leadership), Part Three (the psychological reaction of power on the leaders), Part Six (the oligarchical tendencies of organization; "Democracy and the Iron Law of Oligarchy"). The author's given name is Robert, not George.
- Gaetano Mosca, *The Ruling Class* (Elementi di scienza politica, 1896; trans. Hannah Kahn, 1939), for the organized minority.
- Vilfredo Pareto, *The Mind and Society* (Trattato di sociologia generale, 1916; trans. 1935), for the circulation of elites.
- Peter Bachrach and Morton S. Baratz, "Two Faces of Power," *American Political Science Review* 56:4 (1962), 947 to 952, for the non-decision.
- Bertrand de Jouvenel, *On Power: Its Nature and the History of Its Growth* (Du Pouvoir, 1945; trans. J. F. Huntington, 1948), for the growth of central power in crisis.

Record

All in-video citations link to the Cablecast recording with the `seekto` parameter and are drawn from this project's dialogue files. Meetings cited, by show number: 9853 (SAU 6, 6/14/18), 9986 (9/5/18), 10252 (2/20/19), 10304 (SAU 6, 3/25/19), 10321 (SAU 6, 4/11/19), 10506 (8/21/19), 10521 (9/4/19), 10522 (SAU 6, 9/5/19), 10623 (11/20/19), 10722 (deliberative, 2/1/20), 11007 (10/7/20), 12033 (SAU 6, 11/18/21), 12204 (deliberative, 2/9/22), 14654 (10/5/22), 14681 (10/19/22), 14892 (deliberative, 2/8/23), 14909 (2/15/23), 14937 (3/1/23), 14986 (SAU 6, 3/30/23), 15153 (6/21/23), 15205 (7/19/23), 15357 (10/18/23), 15413 (11/15/23), 15452 (finance subcommittee, 12/6/23), 15523 (SAU 6, 1/11/24), 15531 (1/17/24), 15607 (3/6/24), 15638 (3/20/24), 15947 (8/21/24), 16070 (10/16/24), 16371 (3/5/25), 16530 (5/7/25), 16556 (5/21/25), 16764 (8/14/25), 16776 (8/20/25), 16813 (9/3/25), 16833 (SAU 6, 9/11/25), 16872 (10/1/25), 16951 (11/5/25), 17241 (3/18/26), 17489 (8/5/26). Quotations reproduce the automatic transcript as spoken; the auditor's name is rendered "Campbell" by the transcriber in 2019 and is Michael Campo.

- [Claremont School District Deficit Crisis: Timeline and Fiscal Acts](#) (this project, 9/1/26), for the twelve fiscal acts, the over-return arithmetic, the crisis chronology, the 2023 to 2026 rosters and the reporting by Damien Fisher (NH Journal) and Patrick O'Grady (Valley News) cited there.
- `Scripts/roster_2015_2023.md` and `Scripts/briefing.md`, Addenda 1, 2, 5, 7 and 8, and `Output/HTML/Dialogue/_backlog-attribution-report-2025-2026.md`, for officers, seat changes, appointments and administrative succession 2015 to 2026, with the Valley News items they cite ([10/6/16](#); [11/4/16](#); [2/2/18](#) on the removal of Rapp and Irish; [5/25/18](#); [3/9/19](#); [3/29/19](#); [1/22/20](#)).
- `Output/Reports/signatures-by-era-claremont.csv`, `signatures-by-era-sau6.csv` and `signatures-by-meeting.csv`, produced by `Scripts/era_signatures.py` on 9/27/26.

Statutes

- RSA 198:4-b (retention of unassigned general funds by vote of the legislative body; the 5 per cent cap effective 9/27/20); RSA 198:5; RSA 40:13 (the official ballot deliberative session); RSA 91-A:3 (nonpublic sessions; roll call to enter); RSA 21-J:19 and RSA 197:23-a (audits, permissive); 2 CFR 200.512(a)(1) (single audit deadline); SB 586, 2026 ch. 272 (annual audits mandatory).

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